

Smartbooks

The Return of Linux?

Does the arrival of smartbooks powered by Qualcomm's Snapdragon platform herald a new era of popularity for Linux?

When Asus launched the original eeePC more than a year ago, many industry observers felt that the move finally heralded the arrival of Linux in mainstream consumer products. Although Linux had been around for a while, and was being offered by a number of manufacturers (such as Dell) on their systems, the eeePC was perhaps the first occasion that a Linux-based device had caught the popular imagination. It was felt that different flavours of Linux would dominate the netbook segment (to which devices like the eeePC belonged) as their system requirements were few and were much faster than Windows Vista, Microsoft's then-new operating system.

Microsoft, however, trumped all expectations when it decided to make its popular Windows XP available for netbook manufacturers. Naturally, most consumers gravitated towards the familiar interface and Intel, releasing its Atom processor for netbooks, increased their processing power significantly. The Wintel (Windows+Intel) partnership virtually took over the netbook segment as well. That is not to say that Linux was totally wiped out from these devices—the less expensive netbooks still came with versions of Linux on them, but the possibilities of a “netbook=Linux” equation that the original eeePC had established, no longer existed. In fact, as Atom processors got more powerful, Microsoft even took a leaf out of Ubuntu's book and announced plans to have a special version of its forthcoming operating system, Windows 7, for netbooks. Linux seemed to have had its brief day in the tech sun, just as it had with the Moto Ming in the smartphone segment a few years ago, and looked set to be consigned to the sidelines.

Qualcomm throws the dice!

However, the rumours of Linux's demise in the netbook segment might be premature. Qualcomm recently added a whole new spin to the netbook segment by introducing what it termed ‘smartbooks’, devices that are a blend of notebooks and smartphones. Most of the attention has been on the Snapdragon ARM processors powering these devices and the fact that they come with integrated Bluetooth, GPS, HSPA+ and Wi-Fi, apart from ensuring longer battery life. However, what has not been highlighted is that these devices are not shrunk notebooks but more like expanded smartphones. The devices are actually closer to cell phones than to notebooks, coming with in-built connectivity features that one tends to find in smartphones. In essence, a smartbook is going to be a device that has a cell phone-like interface and features, but with a larger screen and keypad—shades of Palm's ill-fated Foleo, a notebook that could be paired with a smartphone to access features that were on the phone.

What makes this cell phone linkage important is that smartbooks are not likely to be running conventional desktop operating systems like Ubuntu or Windows, but tweaked versions of cell phone operating systems. And this is exactly where many observers feel that Linux might suddenly return to the mainstream. Many of the manufacturers believed to be working on smartbooks are actually considering using Android, Google's much-publicised open source mobile OS, for their devices. Qualcomm actually showed a version of the eeePC running Android, while Acer announced that it would be coming out with an Android-driven netbook (not smartbook, do note) later this year. Besides, with HP believed to be working on Android-